Indigo in cultures and traditions

Indigo is a colour that people grew, traded, wore and also fought battles over. Behind the beauty of its shade stand **both work and pain**. Let us look attentively and gently at a few places, because some of these stories are heavy.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how indigo is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image. For each tradition I say what really stands in it and what is a later interpretation.

Indigo in different cultures

Japan

Indigo is a traditional colour in Japan and to this day it is called “Japanese blue”. In the Edo period (1603 to 1867) common people were forbidden to wear silk, and so cotton and indigo were used more. Dyeing was done in fermentation vats and fabrics were decorated with the techniques shibori, kasuri, katazome and tsutsugaki.

From a practical and later also aesthetic tradition. Indigo was available and durable. The emblem of the Tokyo Olympic Games was a chequerboard in indigo blue (the ichimatsu moyo pattern from the Edo period), which was meant to express elegance and “unity in diversity”.

A colour born of necessity can become **national elegance**. **Restriction often gives birth to beauty**.

India

In India indigo has been grown since antiquity and from there the dye reached Europe. In colonial times it became a crop that some peasants were forced to grow. In 1859 the Bengal uprising against exploitation arose and the play Nil Darpan tells of it. In 1917 in Champaran peasants were obliged to sow part of their land with indigo and Gandhi undertook his first act of civil disobedience in India there.

From the colonial exploitation of agricultural labour. **The action led to a settlement** and the end of this system.

A colour that we wear quite naturally may have behind it **a story that is good not to forget**.

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West Africa

The dyers of the Yoruba (Nigeria) and the Mandinka (Mali) were known for their skill. In Kano in Nigeria the Kofar Mata dye pits still stand, said to be hundreds of years old. The Tuareg are called “the blue people” because indigo from their robes coloured their skin.

From the trans-Saharan trade and from a craft passed down in families. Today it faces pressure from the city, the environment and the declining interest of young people.

A colour can be **craft, family and memory**. When you wear it, you also wear the work that stands behind it.

The Americas

In the American colonies, for example in South Carolina, in Haiti and in Jamaica, indigo was grown with the labour of enslaved people. Enslaved West Africans brought deep knowledge of growing indigo. In Mesoamerica meanwhile, probably since around 800, Maya blue was made from indigo and clay.

From European trade and from indigenous knowledge passed down through generations. The oldest documented fabric dyed with indigo comes from Huaca Prieta in Peru and is about six thousand years old.

Indigo is a colour that carries **both**. The beauty of indigenous traditions and the pain of forced labour. **Both are true**.

Indigo in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at indigo **a little differently** and some do not actually describe it directly. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. **Indigo is not among the classical colours of the five elements.** It is closest to water, which is linked with black or dark blue. **Water is the element** of winter, cold, the kidneys and bladder and the emotion of fear. Wisdom and the ability to flow are also grouped with it.

Water is in the tradition the element of **depth and reserves**. It is under the surface and waits. When there is enough of it, we are calm, patient and have something to draw from. When there is little, the tradition describes exhaustion and anxiety. When there is too much, it tends to be a cold closing-off and fear.

How it relates to the colour indigo. Indigo is a deep dark blue and can be read as the colour of water. Of depth, winter and rest, but also of reserves and wisdom. **It is not a classical assignment, it is a reading in the spirit of the tradition.** Indigo has no organ circuit of its own.

What you can take from it. Ask whether you have enough water in your life, that is rest and reserves. If not, sleep, warmth, slow eating and quiet help. When there is too much water and you are rather withdrawn and fearful, movement, warmth and small steps outward help.

Ask yourself

“Do I have enough rest in my life? Where am I afraid, although I would rather flow?”

Reserves. Not everything has to go out at once

In the traditional view water relates to storing, winter and the kidney circuit. The kidneys are also credited with storing the essence jing. For our theme the image of reserves is interesting. **Not everything you have has to be spent outward immediately.** Perhaps you know how to push, overcome tiredness and carry on. It is just that you less often recognise the moment when it would be good to stop before exhaustion stops you.

When you no longer need a dark hush

If you spend whole days in the dim and feel disconnected from your surroundings, another dark corner may not suit you. Try keeping indigo in a smaller detail and adding a lighter surrounding, daylight or a warmer material. **You do not have to stay in winter** just because it has a beautiful colour.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor. A colour itself does not strengthen the kidneys and does not replace recovery of strength.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. In it a person is described by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. Indigo is cooling, deep and calming.

How it relates to the colour indigo. Indigo is among the cold dark colours. That is why, according to some sources, it suits where there is too much fire and irritation. **Indigo does not appear in the lists of classical texts as a separate colour, it is a modern consideration.** Sources differ in detail, take it as a general direction, not a rule.

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. **Indigo cools and calms her.** The tradition advises cooling colours, such as blue, green or white. Indigo can be a dark variant.

- **Add indigo**
  A muted indigo blanket or cushion, a darker blue in a bedroom.
- **Add some cool**
  White and green, water, a walk by a river.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, who is often cold. Cool colours may be too cool for vata. A soft, muted indigo can help calm, especially in combination with warm light. **It is best to notice how you really feel in indigo.**

- **Warmer shades**
  Grey indigo, plum. Calm without coldness.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Gentle shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. Dark and cool colours can deepen heaviness even more. The tradition advises **lively warm colours**.

- **Indigo in moderation**
  Only as an accent, not the whole room.
- **Add warmth**
  Orange, yellow or red as a counterweight. A jumper, scarf, tablecloth.

Contemporary colour therapy. Ranga chikitsa

Some contemporary Ayurvedic practitioners use a colour therapy called ranga chikitsa. They ascribe to indigo insight, imagination and quieting, and in excess they also describe restlessness or too deep an immersion in the inner world. For your own experience you can try a simple comparison. Do I prefer a deep indigo by itself, or with a light and warmer companion?

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

Jung did not describe indigo as a separate colour. He did, however, link blue with thinking ("thinking is white or blue, cold as snow") and with the mental process, reason (Greek nous). In 1933 he wrote that the unconscious "usually chooses" blue instead of black. What I write next is my own reflection in the spirit of his thought, not Jung's statement.

How it relates to the colour indigo. Indigo is a darker, deeper blue. It could be the colour of a moment when **thinking sinks into the unconscious**. **A quiet space in which things arrange themselves** into connections before we put them into words.

What you can take from it. When you are overwhelmed by the daily rush, indigo in the form of evening helps. A moment when you ask what you actually felt all day. When, on the contrary, you live only in your own head and perceive nothing through the senses, green (body and senses) or red (feeling) may do you good.

Jung did not want colours to be made into a dictionary. **He himself said** that correspondences change according to the person and culture and appear only "with a certain regularity". **We always ask what it means for you.** Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In it indigo is not a separate colour. It is closest to dark blue and black, which belong to **water**, the element of calm, depth and flow. Water belongs to winter and to the direction north. In the map of the house called the bagua, north is linked with career and life path. Indigo is therefore usually the colour of **calm and depth**, not of brightening.

According to the tradition water feeds wood (which is why green belongs with indigo), metal feeds water. Fire and water, on the other hand, "fight". That is why for a dark blue a balance with a warm colour is recommended, so that the space is not too cold.

Simple tips

- **Want more calm?**
  Start with one indigo piece, for example a cushion or lamp, in a place where you will see it every day.
- **For every day**
  Choose grey indigo or denim. Keep a deep midnight for small accents.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, wool and light and warm colours.
- **Indigo does not suit you?**
  Swap it for another colour. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH **Dark walls make a room cosy** always.

TRUTH It depends on the light. In a small room without windows a dark colour can feel cramped. In a spacious room with good lighting it can be cosy.

MYTH Indigo is suitable for a bedroom because it sends you to sleep.

TRUTH For some calming helps, for others a dark room does not improve sleep. What decides is how it feels to fall asleep in it.

MYTH The more indigo, the more intuition.

TRUTH **A colour does not raise intuition**. It can only create a calm environment in which it is easier to perceive.

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Clothing

Indigo in clothing is calm and trustworthy. It suits when you want to seem composed. When dark colours pull you down, **add a light or warm colour near the face**. Let your body and the mirror advise you.

What indigo works well with

- **Cream and warm white**
  A lighter, softer whole.
- **Wood and linen**
  A more natural and warmer impression.
- **Ochre or yellow**
  A striking light spot.
- **Terracotta and orange**
  A warm companion for a deep blue.
- **Soft pink**
  A softer, more personal expression.
- **Green and black**
  Green recalls a landscape at dusk. Black is a very deep pairing in which differences disappear.

Before you repaint a whole room, try **a throw**, **a fabric** or a larger colour **sample**. Hold a large sample to the wall and look at it in the morning and in the evening in your own lighting. A screen does not replace the shade.

When a whole “fights energetically”, do not look for an invisible flaw. **Try changing one concrete thing**. The proportion of colours, a material, the light or the size of an area. Feng shui has several schools and the recommendations differ. Take them as inspiration for how it feels to live in a space.

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Feng shui room by room

What works, what to watch for and a simple tip.

Living room

What works. An indigo cushion, picture or one wall. **It suits mainly the north part** of a room. **An indigo sofa or armchair** can give a light room a striking centre. Let the rest be light.

What to watch for. If you already have a dark floor, furniture and little daylight, start with a smaller accessory. Another large dark area can strengthen the closed-in feeling that already bothers you.

A simple tip. Linen, wool and wood warm indigo and make it friendlier. Glossy satin and glass cool it and emphasise its hardness.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Indigo can be beautiful on ceramics, lower cabinets or place mats. In a light space it creates a striking **contrast that lets the food stand out**.

What to watch for. In a small dark kitchen a smaller amount may be more pleasant. Blue lighting over food as the main light I would not choose. It changes the look of the food.

A simple tip. Matt ceramics or wood with indigo feel friendlier than glossy lacquer. Natural materials ground it and bring it closer to the food.

Bedroom

What works. A soft, muted indigo can help with calming. Indigo bed linen can be pleasant if you like deep colours and a feeling of being enveloped. **Start with a textile.** You will find out how you feel next to it in the morning and in the evening, and it is easy to change.

What to watch for. Whole walls in a dark colour can feel heavy, so balance them with warm textiles. If a room feels cold, try cream, linen or wood.

A simple tip. Cotton and linen in indigo are pleasant to look at and to touch. Gloss does not make falling asleep much easier. What do you see just before you fall asleep and how does it feel to look at it?

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Children's room

What works. A night sky by agreement. Only as an accent, not the whole room. An indigo throw or cushion is soft and easy to replace.

What to watch for. Children need more light. One child will love an indigo corner, another will not want to fall asleep in it. When a child is afraid of a dark place, their experience takes precedence over the rule that blue calms.

Study

What works. Indigo helps concentration in a small dose. It can stand out on a bookcase, a picture or a smaller wall. If it pleases you, it supports the personal character of a workplace.

What to watch for. A too dark room tires. For reading and detailed work you need suitable lighting. When dark surroundings dull you, keep the main work view lighter.

A simple tip. Matt wood or paper leave indigo in the background. A glossy dark surface in the field of view can reflect into the eyes.

Hall and entrance

What works. Put an indigo accent where good light will surround it. A coat hook, a shelf, a small picture.

What to watch for. Dark colours reduce light, so it needs good lighting.

A simple tip. A matt coating or textile can take knocks and does not reflect light as harshly as gloss. **Does the entrance welcome you**, or does the first look shout at you?

If I asked you now

"Why do I want indigo at home? What is it meant to bring me, calm, depth or focus?"

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